C1 Reading

Recognising text structure

Identify how a text is organised, such as problem and solution or cause and effect, to read faster and predict what comes next.

Longer texts follow recognisable patterns. Once you see the pattern, you know where to look for the main argument, you can predict the next paragraph, and gapped-text exam tasks become much easier.

Structure	Typical signals	Where the key point is
Problem and solution	*The difficulty is… One answer may be… This would address…*	The proposed solution and its evaluation
Cause and effect	*As a result, This has led to, owing to, consequently*	The link between the two
Comparison and contrast	*Whereas, By contrast, Similarly, Unlike*	What the comparison shows
Claim and counter-claim	*It is often said that… Yet… Critics argue… Nevertheless,…*	The writer's final position, often after *yet* or *nevertheless*
Chronological	*Initially, Subsequently, By the 1990s, Since then*	The turning point or current state

Read first and last sentences of each paragraph. Together they usually reveal the structure in under a minute, before you read the details.

Common mistake. Taking the first view in a claim and counter-claim text as the writer's own. *It is often argued that…* usually introduces a view the writer will challenge.

Read the text

> Many coastal cities face a growing shortage of fresh water. Rising populations and hotter summers have pushed demand far beyond what rivers and wells can supply. Desalination is often presented as the obvious answer. Yet it is expensive and energy-hungry, and the salty waste it produces can harm marine life. A more sustainable approach may combine smaller desalination plants powered by solar energy with strict limits on water waste in homes and agriculture.

Practice

1. What is the overall structure of the text?
2. Which sentence explains the cause of the problem?
3. Which word signals that the writer is about to criticise desalination?
4. What is the writer's own solution?
5. Is the writer completely against desalination? Explain.

▼ **Show answers**

1. Problem and solution (with a counter-claim).
2. Rising populations and hotter summers have pushed demand far beyond what rivers and wells can supply.
3. Yet
4. Smaller solar-powered desalination plants combined with strict limits on water waste.
5. No. They reject large-scale desalination as the only answer but still include smaller, solar-powered plants.